

STRENGTHENING SEXUAL AND REPRODUCTIVE HEALTH AND RIGHTS

Evaluation findings against the backdrop of a changed international context

The German Institute for Development Evaluation (DEval) examined the area of intervention “Population dynamics; sexual and reproductive health and rights (SRHR)” of the Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development (BMZ) for the period 2011 to 2023. According to the current coalition agreement, this area of intervention is one of the priorities of development policy within this legislative period. This policy brief discusses the evaluation findings against the backdrop of current challenges.

Current international context for SRHR

In 2025, various donor countries have announced cuts to their funding for international development. These include five of the ten largest donor countries for activities to strengthen sexual and reproductive health and rights (SRHR). Germany is one of them. In some of these countries, the cuts are linked to an increasing questioning of specific aspects of SRHR, particularly sexual and reproductive rights (SRR). This is particularly evident in the USA: besides the dissolution of the development agency USAID, funding for UN organisations dealing with SRHR (such as UNFPA, WHO and UN Women) is being selectively cut. Moreover, the reintroduction of the so-called “global gag rule” prohibits non-governmental organisations receiving US funding from offering safe pregnancy terminations and related information and counselling services.

Similar trends can be observed in other donor countries. These are manifesting themselves in a growing anti-gender movement, which is particularly opposed to SRR (German Bundestag, 2023). At the same time, SRHR are also being called into question in an increasing number of partner countries of German development cooperation.

Marginalised groups are particularly hard hit by the cuts. Restrictions and cuts to the provision of SRHR services are exacerbating social and gender inequalities and increasing barriers to accessing these services. This also applies to crisis regions:

although two-thirds of global pregnancy- and childbirth-related deaths affect mothers in fragile countries, many women's rights organisations in crisis contexts already report having ceased activities due to funding cuts (UN Women, 2025). Estimates show that cuts in SRHR funding could lead to a very large worldwide increase in unintended pregnancies, unsafe pregnancy terminations and maternal mortality (Damavandi et al., 2025).

Evaluation findings against the backdrop of current context conditions

Mitigating the impacts of cuts on SRR and inclusion

The evaluation shows that the projects examined largely achieve their intended impacts; for example, they contribute to strengthening health facilities in partner countries. However, it also clearly emerges that sexual and reproductive *rights* are promoted less than sexual and reproductive *health*. Few interventions focus on the sexual and reproductive autonomy of girls and women, for example. Marginalised groups also often have limited access to SRHR services and products, such as contraceptives. One of the reasons why these deficits are not being addressed more is that some interview partners consider using funds for health activities and for large target groups to be more efficient. Furthermore, there is a lack of disaggregated data on marginalised groups.

This situation may be exacerbated by cuts in development cooperation funding, for example because effective SRHR interventions cannot be continued or because rights-based and inclusive activities are given lower priority. To counteract this, DEval recommends stronger management of the holistic implementation of the area of intervention, for example through standardised indicators that also cover the rights-related objectives of the interventions. Furthermore, disaggregated indicators for marginalised groups should be included and approaches for the targeted empowerment of such groups should be piloted.

**Figure 1** Current international context for SRHR and corresponding evaluation findings

Current international context for SRHR	Drop in development-policy funding for SRHR	FINDING OF THE EVALUATION - Interventions examined are mostly effective and impactful - Deprioritisation of activities for rights and marginalised groups	RECOMMENDATIONS OF THE EVALUATION - Strengthen implementation of the holistic approach - Implement targeted measures for marginalised groups
	Questioning of SRHR in the donor community	FINDING OF THE EVALUATION - Evidence of effectiveness and impact of approaches - Overview of existing scientific evidence	RECOMMENDATIONS OF THE EVALUATION Systematically implement an evidence agenda in German development cooperation
	Questioning of SRHR in partner countries	FINDING OF THE EVALUATION Limited interest of partner governments may impede implementation of rights	RECOMMENDATIONS OF THE EVALUATION Create enabling environments for work on rights, according to the interest of partner governments

Source: DEval, authors' own graphic

Use differentiated approaches, promote evidence-based objectivity

The lack of focus on SRR may also be due to a lack of interest in strengthening these rights on the part of partner governments. This reluctance could increase in the future. Therefore, DEval recommends a differentiated approach: the holistic approach to strengthening SRHR should be implemented with partner governments that are also interested in working together on SRR. In other partner countries where German development

cooperation focuses on this area of intervention, a policy context favourable to strengthening SRR should first be promoted.

Evidence of the effectiveness and impact of interventions can help to objectify the normative debate on SRHR. DEval therefore recommends that German development cooperation actors compile evidence on the effectiveness and impact of different approaches, and take this into account when further developing their portfolio. To this end, it provides an evidence map on SRHR ([on the 3ie website](#)).

Literature

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The German Institute for Development Evaluation (DEval) is mandated by the German Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development (BMZ) to independently analyse and assess German development interventions. Evaluation reports contribute to the transparency of development results and provide policy-makers with evidence and lessons learned, based on which they can shape and improve their development policies.